Chapter Two

The Bearded One *(El Barbudo)*

‘I cannot ever see him as a good routine, line-toeing communist. His strength lies in his individuality. Shave off his beard, put him into a collar and tie and business suit and I am not sure at all he could hold down his job.’[1]

(Herbert ‘Bill’ Marchant, British Ambassador to Cuba)

‘Pamphlets should be dropped on the island warning that atomic testing had made the Cuban atmosphere radioactive: radioactivity made men impotent and lingered longest in beards. Cubans would shave off their beards. Without bearded Cubans, revolution would cease.’[2]

(Ian Fleming, novelist)

‘The thought being [among CIA officials] to destroy Castro’s image as “The Beard” by causing the beard to fall out … the idea originated in connection with a trip Castro was to have made outside Cuba. The idea was to dust thallium powder into Castro’s shoes when they were put out at night to be shined.’ [3]

(J.S. Earman, CIA Inspector General)

‘If one has faith in the human values of the United States, and if that faith is supported by vigorous and intelligent action, then there is no need to fear competition from an unshaven megalomaniac.’[4]